

Chenjun Yu (she/her)

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Postsecondary pathways; community colleges; CTE; workforce development; economic mobility.
- Causal inference; quantitative and mixed methods; measurement in administrative data.
- Financial aid; transfer and articulation; policy evaluation; state policy design and campus implementation.

EDUCATION

- May 2027 (exp.) **Ph.D.**, Public Policy in Postsecondary Education, University of Michigan
 Dissertation: *Working and Learning in Hard Times: How Employment Downturns Shape Community College Students' School and Job Trajectories*
 Committee: Brian McCall (chair), Walt Ecton, Katherine Micheltmore, Stacey Brockman
- June 2022 **M.A.**, Education Economics & Management, Tsinghua University
 Thesis: *Family Background, Vocational Education and Economic Returns*. Advisor: Fengliang Li
- June 2019 **B.A.**, Japanese Language & Literature, Tsinghua University

ADVANCED TRAINING

- 2026 Preparing Future Faculty Program, University of Michigan (selected)
- 2025 Arnold Ventures Innovation Day, APPAM and AEFPP (selected)
- 2025 IES CTE Research Network 2.0 Summer Training Institute (selected)
- 2024 ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods and ICPSR–MIDAS Social Data Science Summer Academy (full scholarship)

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- Li, F., & Yu, C. (2022). A study on adjusting the national financial aid amount for master's students: Three estimating approaches. *Journal of Northwestern Polytechnical University (Social Sciences)*. [in Chinese] [\[Link\]](#)
 Constructs a cost-of-living index for master's students across China, finding that the National Stipend covers roughly 60% of basic costs and shows substantial geographical variation.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW

- Yu, C., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., Kreth, Q., & May-Trifiletti, J. Who counts? Identifying career and technical education students at community colleges using state administrative data. Under Review, *Community College Review*.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

- Yu, C. Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' enrollment and labor market trajectories. *Draft available upon request*. ★ **Job market paper**
- Yu, C. Working while enrolled in college: A systematic review of the evidence, 2005–2025. *Draft available upon request*.

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. Effects of financial aid on student academic and labor market outcomes: The case of Tennessee HOPE. *Draft available upon request.*

Trigger, J. M., **Yu, C.,** Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. Financial aid administrators' perspectives on students' experiences with financial aid. *Draft available upon request.*

SELECT POLICY REPORTS & BRIEFS

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Wang, M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). *White Paper 5: Effect of HOPE renewal on labor market outcomes.* Tennessee Higher Education Commission & CSHPE, University of Michigan. *Under Agency Review.*

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Wang, M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). *White Paper 3: Effect of HOPE receipt on labor market outcomes.* Tennessee Higher Education Commission & CSHPE, University of Michigan. *Under Agency Review.*

Trigger, J. M., **Yu, C.,** Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). The effect of receiving Tennessee HOPE on labor market outcomes, 2010–2023. In *Tennessee Education Lottery Scholarship Program 2025 Annual Report* (pp. 38–41). [\[Link\]](#)

Bahr, P. R., **Yu, C.,** Columbus, R., Kreth, Q., & May-Trifiletti, J. (forthcoming). *Who participates in stackable credential pathways? Evidence from Ohio community colleges.* CSHPE, University of Michigan.

Kreth, Q., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., **Yu, C.,** & May-Trifiletti, J. (forthcoming). *Work and industry change among students in stackable credential pathways.* CSHPE, University of Michigan.

May-Trifiletti, J., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., **Yu, C.,** & Daugherty, L. (2024). *Do low-income students stack high-value credentials?* (Working Paper 24-1). CSHPE, University of Michigan. [\[Link\]](#)

BOOK CHAPTERS

Yu, C. (2024). Overview: Introduction and conceptual framework. In F. Li (Ed.), *Current situation, problems and countermeasures of adult learning and education.* Zhongguo Shehui Chubanshe. [in Chinese]

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

Estimating the effect of the Tennessee HOPE Scholarship on academic and labor market outcomes. *Tennessee Higher Education Commission Summer 2026 Commission Meeting*, Clarksville, TN, July 2026. (Co-presented; led presentation of quantitative findings.)

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

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| 2026 | Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' trajectories. <i>SREE</i> , Baltimore, MD. |
| 2026 | Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' school and job trajectories. <i>SFARN</i> , Louisville, KY. |
| 2025 | Effect of financial aid on labor market outcomes: The case of Tennessee HOPE. <i>APPAM</i> , Seattle, WA. |
| 2025 | Financial aid administrators' perspectives on students' experiences with financial aid. <i>ASHE</i> , Denver, CO. |
| 2025 | Work through recession? Unpacking students' working and borrowing behaviors during economic shocks. <i>CSCC</i> , Detroit, MI. |
| 2025 | Estimating the labor market outcomes of state merit-aid scholarships. <i>AEEP</i> , Washington, DC. |
| 2025 | Tracking the gains of higher education: A review of gainful employment policy. <i>CIES</i> , Chicago, IL. |

2024	Working students during recession: An instrumental variables approach. <i>AEFP</i> , Baltimore, MD.
2021	Dispelling misconceptions: Did vocational colleges reinforce social stratification in China? <i>AERA</i> , virtual.
2020	How to break the isolation of writing: A peer writing advising program in China. <i>NACADA</i> , virtual.

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

2026–27	Rackham Predoctoral Fellowship , University of Michigan (\$44,000) ~85 awarded from ~240 university-wide nominees
2026	Spencer Scholarship , APPAM (\$1,500)
2026	Researchers of Color Mentored Travel Award , SREE (\$1,500)
2025	Postsecondary CTE Research Fellowship , ECMC Foundation–Old Dominion University (\$2,500) National cohort of 9
2025	Rackham Graduate Research Grant , University of Michigan (\$1,500)
2024–26	CSHPE Summer Support Grants , University of Michigan (\$4,200 total)
2024	ISR–Rackham Summer Training Award , University of Michigan (\$3,000)
2023–26	Rackham Conference Travel Grants , University of Michigan (\$900 × 4)
2022–23	Karl C.K. Ma Endowed Fellowship , University of Michigan (\$36,000)
2022	Outstanding Contribution Award to International Student Affairs , Tsinghua University
2019–21	Comprehensive Excellence Scholarship , Tsinghua University (×3; top 20%)

RESEARCH POSITIONS

2022–	Graduate Student Research Assistant , University of Michigan - Lead quantitative analyst, IES-funded evaluation of Tennessee state merit aid affecting 30,000+ students annually (PIs: McCall, DesJardins, Klafehn); RD and IV designs on statewide longitudinal records linked to UI wage data. - Co-led qualitative arm: designed protocols, conducted 18 interviews with financial aid administrators across Tennessee institutions. - Analyzed stackable credential pathways and wage outcomes, Ohio community colleges ($n > 30,000$), longitudinal enrollment + UI wage data (PI: Bahr).
2025–26	Research Assistant , Detroit Partnership for Education Equity and Research, Wayne State University - Built an original statewide dataset of Maryland program-level articulation agreements from hundreds of unstandardized documents via AI-assisted extraction; analyzed credit applicability and excess credits among vertical transfer students (PIs: Brockman, Lin). - Evaluated open educational resources policies across five Michigan community colleges using difference-in-differences designs.
2018–22	Research Assistant , Tsinghua University Led a research team producing a national policy report on adult learning and education; policy analysis in partnership with the National Student Financial Aid Center (PI: Li).

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2019–22	Project Manager , Academic Support Program, Tsinghua University
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- Directed a program serving 1,500+ advising sessions annually; supervised 20 graduate advisors and 3 undergraduate assistants; managed budget, training materials, and quality assurance.
- Redesigned delivery model during the COVID-19 transition; 98% student satisfaction, 120% enrollment growth.

2021 **Education Programme Intern**, UNESCO Beijing Cluster Office

- Drafted policy reports on regional TVET initiatives with a focus on equity and access in Mongolia; coordinated stakeholder convenings with government and civil society partners.

TEACHING AND MENTORING

2025– **Research Mentor**, University of Michigan

- Mentor two master's students on a faculty-led research team in question formulation, analytic strategy, and interpretation.

2026 **Guest Lecturer**, University of West Georgia

- *ECON 1101, Economics of Financial Literacy*: lecture on college affordability, financial aid, and degree persistence.

2020–21 **Instructional Assistant**, Tsinghua University

- *Academic Writing and Critical Thinking* (undergraduate, ~15 students): led discussion sections; evaluated 30+ essays per term.
- *College Student Psychological Development* (undergraduate, 3 semesters, ~80 students/term): small-group tutoring; assessment of applied theory projects.

Courses prepared to teach: Research design for education policy · Applied causal inference · Introduction to higher education policy · Community college policy · Quantitative and mixed methods

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Methods	Causal inference (RD, DiD, IV, shift-share, matching); survey design and analysis; semi-structured interviewing; thematic and grounded theory coding; systematic review and framework synthesis
Software	Stata (advanced), R, Python; Tableau; Dedoose
Data	Longitudinal administrative data linkage and cleaning (state unit-record enrollment/transcript/UI wage systems; NSC, NLSY, IPEDS, QCEW)
Languages	Chinese (native), English (fluent), Japanese (advanced)

SERVICE

Field	Award reviewer, CIES and CSCC (2026); Session organizer and chair, APPAM (2026); Conference proposal reviewer, SREE (2025), CSCC, CIES, AERA (2024); AEFPP Conference Ambassador (2026)
Institution	Marsal Student Advisory Board (2026); Executive Board, Students of Color of Rackham (2023–24)
Member	AEFP · APPAM · ASHE · CSCC · SREE · CIES · AIR · ACTER

Last updated: October 4, 2026